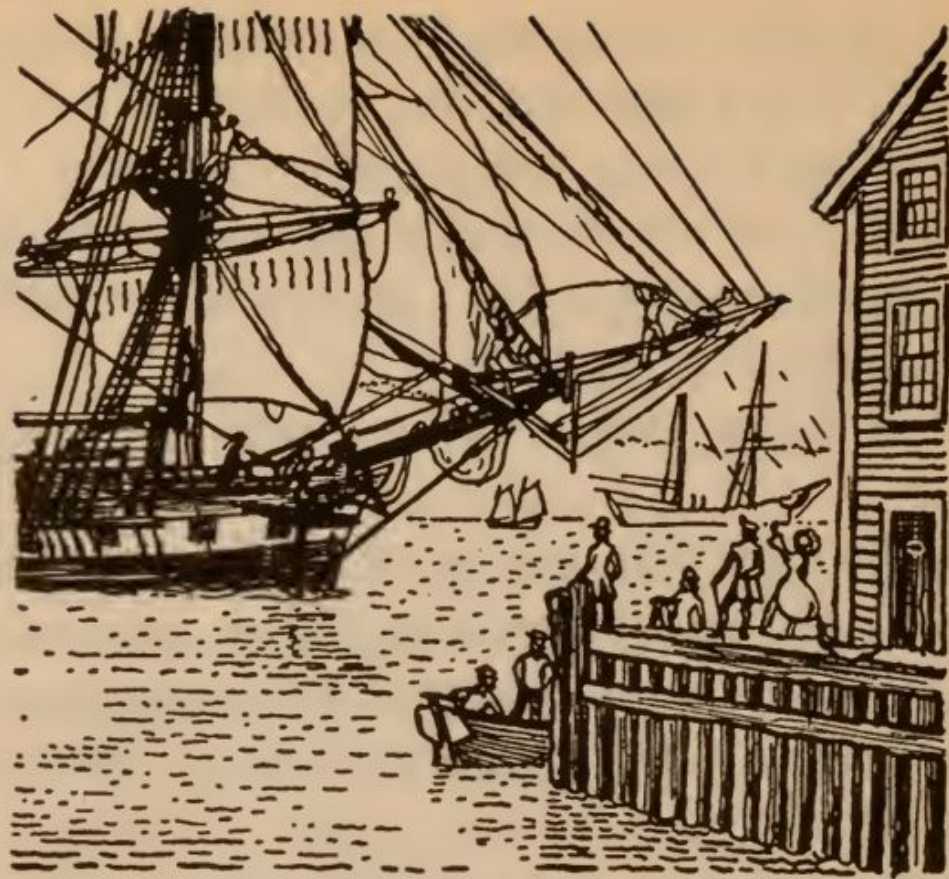


Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 19



CHAPTER 19



STRANGE SAILING ORDERS

Nat thought he had learned to face his sorrow, until they sighted Cape Ann and he knew that in a few hours he would be home. His hands began to shake. Desperately he tried to keep his mind on the rocks and shoals of the entrance to Salem Harbor. Gales Ledge to starboard . . . Pilgrim Ledge . . .

What could he say to Elizabeth's mother?

Whaleback to starboard now . . . and a good berth to the northwest point of Baker's Island . . .

What was there to say that wouldn't sound hollow and empty?

Midchannel now between Baker's Island and Little Misery. Nat stared toward Naugus Head and Coney Island. Must keep them in line . . .

If only he had a way with words he could give her some comfort!

Hardy's Rocks on the south . . . the Rising States Ledge . . . the shoals of Eagle Island. On the north, Bowditch Ledge . . .

Elizabeth's mother would probably hate the sight of him. He'd only remind her of the happy months last summer, before he had sailed.

"I'll tell her I want to return Elizabeth's dowry — leave everything just as it is. I'll say I have to stay with the ship while we unload the cargo. I'll get out. That will make it easier for her."

Captain Prince's voice said, "Southwest by south."

They were almost there. Soon Abbot's Rock to starboard . . .

Almost home! Nat drew a quivering breath.

When they had anchored, Captain Prince said, "Go along, Mr. Bowditch. You aren't needed here."

"Aye, aye, sir." Nat left the ship.

Polly was waiting on Derby Wharf. She stretched out both hands to him and kissed his cheek. "Dear Nat. Aunt Mary's so anxious to see you. I came to meet you. I thought if I told you about Elizabeth it would be easier."

"You're like what Lizza used to say of *her*, Polly. You have eyes in the back of your heart."

Polly shook her head quickly and winked back tears. "I'm not a bit like Elizabeth. But I loved her. And — I'm like Aunt Mary. I love you, too, because you made Elizabeth so happy."

They walked slowly home, and she told him of Elizabeth. It had been consumption. "It takes more people than the sea, doesn't it, Nat? I wonder if doctors will ever find a way to conquer it — the way they are conquering smallpox?"

Mrs. Boardman was waiting for him. "It's good to have you home, Nat. I've missed you."

The lump of dread in his heart went away. It was not until after supper, when he climbed the stairs, that the awful aloneness hit him. He turned toward the big corner room where he had said good-by to Elizabeth. He stood by the closed door, unable to open it.

Polly came up the stairs with a lighted lamp. "I've fixed the east bedroom for you, Nat. Sort of like a study — with a desk and all."

Nat followed her to the room — saw the bookcases, the big desk, the armchair he had liked. He said again, "You do have eyes in the back of your heart."

Three men from the *Astrea* tramped up the stairs, bringing his gear.

Polly whispered, "I sent for your things." She called, "In here, please!"

The men looked around the room and nodded. They declared it was a proper berth for Mr. Bowditch — him with his tables of figures, long as main to bowline. They tramped down the stairs again.

Polly said, "I hope you have something to work on — hard."

"Why are you both so good to me?"

"Pure selfishness," Polly told him. "We like to have you here."

It was more than a week later before Nat got around to what he had wanted to tell Elizabeth's mother — about returning the dowry. "We had such a short time together. I don't deserve to keep anything."

Mrs. Boardman said, "You proud, foolish *man!* I never want to hear another word about it!" She seemed to think she had settled that and went on talking about something else.

Dr. Bentley brought Nat up to date on the news of Salem. Mr. Derby was broken in health — dying — but he had accomplished that last dream of his — to have Salem build a frigate for the United States Navy. He had advanced ten thousand dollars of the seventy-six thousand needed. Dr. Bentley showed Nat a copy of the broadside that had been printed to announce the building of the ship:

THE SALEM FRIGATE TAKE NOTICE:

Ye Sons of Freedom! All true lovers of the Liberty of your country! Step forth and give your assistance in building the Frigate to oppose French insolence and piracy. Let every man in possession of a White Oak Tree be ambitious to be foremost in hurrying down the timber to Salem, and fill the complement wanting, where the noble structure is to be fabricated, to maintain your rights upon the Seas, and make the name of America respected among the nations of the world.

Your largest and longest trees are wanted, and the arms of them for Knees and Rising Timber. Four trees are wanted for the Keel, which all together will measure 146 feet in length, and hew 16 inches square.

Polly went with Nat, Dr. Bentley, and Captain Prince to see the Salem frigate in the ways.

Dr. Bentley stared at the hull that was taking shape. "Elias Hasket Derby's last dream," he said. "Free men of Salem, building a ship to defend America."

"We're going to need it some day," Prince said. "Mr. Derby knew. That man always could see around corners."

They went to the Derby wharf. A strange crew was aboard the *Astrea*, making ready to sail. Some men in Boston had bought the ship. Captain Prince watched the crew. "Lubbers; I wouldn't sail with that crew if they gave me the ship!"

Nat spoke before he thought. "I would. Right now I'd sail on anything, to anywhere. I'd . . ." He stopped, embarrassed.

Captain Prince and Dr. Bentley were embarrassed for him. They began to talk about something else.

Polly looked squarely into his eyes. "I know you would. I don't blame you."

Bless Polly, she did understand. She knew that friends and neighbors — even old friends and good neighbors — couldn't fill the emptiness in his heart.

When he and Polly reached home there was a letter waiting for Nat. He had been elected a Fellow of the American Academy of Arts and Sciences! It seemed to Nat his mind fumbled, trying to grasp the meaning, as cold fingers fumble, trying to untie a knot.

“Nat! How wonderful!” Mrs. Boardman said. “I — I — must see Mary Crowninshield! I just remembered something . . . ” And she put on her bonnet and hurried out.

Polly’s eyes twinkled. “Salem will know about this before dark, from Gallow’s Hill to the Beverly landing!” Then she sobered. “I wish it had come sooner, Nat.” She did not say more; she did not need to.

In the days that followed she had fun bringing Nat

reports of Salem's reaction to the news. Not everyone knew what it was all about — but they were sure it was fine. Science? They knew Nat had worked out something about navigation. Was that science? Navigation was just navigation, wasn't it? Getting your ship there and back? It didn't take a scientist to do that, did it? Scientists were bearded men who read heavy books and talked big words, weren't they? Who ever heard of a scientist going to sea?

Captain Prince came around one evening. "Did you mean what you said, Nat — that you'd sail anywhere on anything?"

“Yes, I did.”

“Then you’ll get your wish. The new owners of the *Astrea* want us to go as master and supercargo — to Batavia, for coffee.” He smiled grimly. “They assure me I can pick up a better crew in Boston than the one we saw handling the ship.”

Nat said, “At least they’ll be better — when you get done with them.”

“Most of our men are scattered, but I did see Charlie Waldo.”

Nat grinned. “Fine; it’s always a help to have a handy cabin boy.”

Prince stood. "Then you'll go? I'll write them tonight. We'd better drive to Boston when the time comes. The stage might not have room for all your gear."

Hab and William both were in port before Nat left for Boston. Tanned, brawny fellows that they were, they teased Nat, asking him how he kept his feet in a squall. But their teasing was mixed with respect. They had been hearing tales from men who had sailed under him.

The night before their ships sailed again, Hab and William came to supper in the Boardman home, and filled the room with their laughter and tall tales.

“Did Nat ever tell you about the time he worked problems on a powder keg?”

Mrs. Boardman said, “Dear me! I hope the keg was empty!”

Hab chuckled. “Not much it wasn’t! The little runt was sitting right in the middle of the powder room! For three solid hours!”

“Nathaniel!” Mrs. Boardman gasped. “I hope I never hear of your doing anything like that again!”

Polly’s brown eyes danced. “You won’t,” she said, “unless someone tells on him.”

After supper, Mr. Blunt came to call. He was about to bring out another edition of Moore, he said. Would Nat go over the whole book — if he had time — his next voyage — and check it for errors?

Nat said he intended to do that very thing.

Mr. Blunt beamed. “Good! I’ll consider it a personal favor!”

“It’s no personal favor to you — or to any publisher!” Nat barked. “I’m doing it for the men who depend on it when they sail!”

Mr. Blunt’s famous temper started rising. His face swelled and turned red. But he swallowed hard. “Quite so, Mr. Bowditch. Quite so.”

When Mr. Blunt had gone, Hab grinned and shook his head. "William, the little runt has a temper!"

William smiled at Nat. "Only about things that matter."

They took Nat with them to see Mary and Lois. Mary smiled at them lovingly. "I'm so proud of you — all three of you! Sit down — and let me just *look* at you! It's been so long since we were all together!"

They talked until the birds began a sleepy twitter.

William looked out the door. "Hab! It's almost daylight!"

“Come on!” Hab bellowed, “or we’ll be making a pier-head jump!”

So the good-bys were brief. It was better that way, Nat thought. He wished his good-bys could be as short when he’d leave for Boston. They wouldn’t be. He’d leave Salem with Captain Prince. The master of a vessel didn’t have to make a pier-head jump. Everything waited for him.

If only he didn’t have to say good-by to anyone. Especially to Polly. Young girls were always the worst of it, he told himself. The night before he and Captain Prince were to leave, he spent the evening with Mary and Lois.

He'd be in a hurry tomorrow, he told himself. That would cut short the good-bys.

When he returned to his room late, there was a note on his desk from Polly. She had had to go to Danvers — she said.

. . . I suppose I should say I'm sorry to miss telling you good-by, but I'm not. I don't think much of good-bys, do you? Have a good journey! . . .

Blast that girl! Nat crushed the note, hurled it on the floor, then picked it up, smoothed it, and put it away in a book.

He was still muttering to himself when he and Captain Prince started to drive to Boston. Captain Prince gave him a sidelong glance. "A little shy of ballast, aren't you, Mr. Bowditch? A crank little vessel this morning."

Nat did not answer.

At last they reached Boston and drove to the wharf. They went aboard the *Astrea*, and found her deserted of all but a watchman. Such a crew, he complained. Not the first crew — the second one. The owners had advanced a month's wages to the men, to clear their debts. They'd brought them on board, and fed them well. Then the scoundrels had jumped ship.

"Good riddance," Prince said.

They went to see the owners, and met the first and second mates. Mr. Cheevers, the first mate — slim, hard-bitten — looked capable enough. but bad-tempered. Mr. Towsen, the second mate, had his berth at the request of one of the owners.

We're probably supposed to "make a man of him," Nat thought.

The owners, too, apologized about the crew. They'd had no idea the men would jump ship, or they'd have taken precautions.

"Good riddance," Prince said again. "We'll find a better lot."

But when they had scoured the waterfront boarding-houses, Prince shook his head over their scourings. They picked the best of the lot, advanced a month's wages to settle their debts, and signed them on. The men came aboard — some walking — some being dragged.

By evening the crew was aboard, and the *Astrea* was cleared to sail. Nothing to do now but wait for the tide.

Captain Prince said, "Mr. Cheevers, how soon can you get under way?"

Mr. Cheevers was so astounded that he stuttered, "You — you're — the tide —"

"Mr. Cheevers!"

"Aye, aye, sir!" Mr. Cheevers gave orders.

A baffled, bewildered crew blundered on deck, and walked round the capstan.

"Hove short, sir," Mr. Cheevers reported.

"Set jib and mainsail, Mr. Cheevers."

"Aye, aye, sir."

Prince watched in grim silence while the men fumbled with the sails. Then he said, "Break her out, Mr. Cheevers!"

And the *Astrea* was under way.

Nat saw the sidelong glances Mr. Cheevers shot toward the captain. He could read Mr. Cheevers' thought — Are we sailing with a madman?

Presently, Captain Prince said, "So, Mr. Cheevers. Ready with your anchors."

More bewildered than ever, Mr. Cheevers shouted orders. The *Astrea* came to again, and anchored. Captain Prince cast a look over the long way back toward the shore. "Call your men aft, Mr. Cheevers."

Nat had heard Prince talk to his crews three times, but he had never heard anything like this talk. Prince finished by advising them not to jump ship, since they were hardly in condition to swim that far. With that, Prince turned on his heel and went below.

Now the meaning of the strange sailing time dawned on the crew. Nat looked at Mr. Cheevers and saw anger, amusement, and respect in his eyes. But the faces of the men before the mast were frightening to watch. Not two of the lot, Nat figured, had had the slightest intention of sailing on the *Astrea*. They had doubtless heard of the

clever desertion of the other crew. They'd planned the same stunt, signed on for a square meal and a month's pay. Now they faced months at sea — the terrors of the Cape — the grilling passage through Sunda Strait — a layover in Batavia — where men died like flies.

The baffled rage was naked on their faces.

Charlie Waldo approached Nat. "The captain's compliments, Mr. Bowditch. He'll see you below."

Captain Prince said nothing about the scene on deck. He was not even wearing his grim go-to-sea look. He

spoke softly, with a drawl. "We'll stand anchor watch tonight, Mr. Bowditch, along with our crew. So they won't get lonesome. If we get past tonight with a full crew, they won't have another chance to jump ship till the Cape. After tonight we can rest easy."

We can rest easy . . . With a dozen men who probably hated the sight of their captain? With a dozen landlubbers whose only recommendation for the sea was that they had failed on land? Nat wondered.